

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Sāṃkhya - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Sāṃkhya

REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST

01

CONTEMPORARY-ANCHOR DISCIPLINE

Contemporary-anchor discipline: A February 2026 academic lecture on

02

MASTER DISTINCTION GATEWAY

Master verdict: Sāṃkhya is a realist dualism and evolutionism: Prakṛti

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Sāṃkhya - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed. across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

Questions 1-40 diagnose core doctrine and exam traps. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed.

1. Which set exhausts the *pramāṇas* admitted by classical Sāṃkhya?

A. Six *pramāṇas* including *anupalabdhi* B. *Pratyakṣa*, *anumāna* and *āptavacana/śabda* C. *Pratyakṣa* alone D. *Pratyakṣa*, *anumāna*, *upamāna* and *śabda*

Answer: B. *Pratyakṣa*, *anumāna* and *āptavacana/śabda*

Explanation: Sāṃkhya accepts perception, inference and trustworthy testimony; other proposed instruments are reduced to these three.

2. Which inference chiefly carries Sāṃkhya from manifest experience to imperceptible *Prakṛti* and *Puruṣa*?

A. *Kevalavyatireki* B. *Sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa* C. *Pūrvavat* D. *Śeṣavat*

Answer: B. *Sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa*

Explanation: *Sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa* works through general correlation where the inferred entity is not an ordinary sense-object.

3. Which statement correctly pairs Sāṃkhya's two ultimate realities?

A. One unconscious *Prakṛti* and many inactive conscious *Puruṣas* B. Many conscious *Prakṛtis* and one *Puruṣa* C. One Brahman appearing as both D. One conscious *Prakṛti* and many active *Puruṣas*

Answer: A. One unconscious *Prakṛti* and many inactive conscious *Puruṣas*

Explanation: *Prakṛti* is the single unconscious material root; *Puruṣas* are many changeless witnesses, never productive agents.

4. Why does imperceptibility not by itself refute *mūla-Prakṛti*?

A. *Puruṣa* perceives it as an object B. Scripture makes inference unnecessary C. *Prakṛti* is a gross element D. Non-perception can result from subtlety, not non-existence

Answer: D. Non-perception can result from subtlety, not non-existence

Explanation: Root *Prakṛti* is *atīndriya* especially through *saukṣmya*, so it must be inferred.

5. Which proof most directly supports the existence of one *Prakṛti*?

A. *Kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtteḥ* B. *Avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya* C. *Asadakaraṇāt* D. *Bhoktr-bhāvāt*

Answer: B. *Avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya*

Explanation: A diversified yet interconnected cosmos points to one undivided unmanifest source.

6. In *bhedānām parimāṇāt*, finite effects indicate:

A. That effects are illusory B. That atoms are conscious C. A subtler material ground from which limitation emerges D. A creator *Puruṣa*

Answer: C. A subtler material ground from which limitation emerges

Explanation: The argument moves from delimited effects to a fundamental material source, not to a creator God.

7. Which statement best captures the status of the guṇas?

- A. Qualities inhering in Puruṣa B. Inseparable constitutive strands of Prakṛti C. Moral labels applied after evolution D. Three independent substances

Answer: B. Inseparable constitutive strands of Prakṛti

Explanation: Sattva, rajas and tamas constitute Prakṛti and occur together in every evolute in varying proportions.

8. What is sāmyāvasthā?

- A. Equilibrium of sattva, rajas and tamas in unmanifest Prakṛti B. Ahaṁkāra appropriating cognition C. Liberation of all Puruṣas D. Rajas dominating both branches

Answer: A. Equilibrium of sattva, rajas and tamas in unmanifest Prakṛti

Explanation: Prakṛti is avyakta in equilibrium; manifestation begins with disequilibrium, not divine creation.

9. Sarūpa-pariṇāma denotes:

- A. Destruction of the guṇas B. New production from prior absence C. Homogeneous change of each guṇa compatible with equilibrium D. Apparent transformation of Brahman

Answer: C. Homogeneous change of each guṇa compatible with equilibrium

Explanation: It is same-form modification within equilibrium, allowing dynamism without differentiated evolutes.

10. Virūpa-pariṇāma begins when:

- A. Mahat becomes conscious B. Guṇa equilibrium is disturbed and unequal predominance develops C. Puruṣa chooses to create D. All karmic traces end

Answer: B. Guṇa equilibrium is disturbed and unequal predominance develops

Explanation: Heterogeneous modification generates diversity. Puruṣa occasions but does not agentively perform it.

11. Which is the first evolute of Prakṛti?

- A. Mahat/buddhi B. Ākāśa C. Ahaṁkāra D. Manas

Answer: A. Mahat/buddhi

Explanation: Mahat, psychologically called buddhi, is first; ahaṁkāra follows.

12. Which statement about rājasa ahaṁkāra is correct?

- A. It is Puruṣa B. It directly produces gross elements C. It energises both sāttvika and tāmasa lines D. It produces a third tattva-set

Answer: C. It energises both sāttvika and tāmasa lines

Explanation: Rajas supplies activity; it does not create a separate set of tattvas.

13. What is buddhi's distinctive function?

- A. Gross action B. Pure witnessing C. Coordination only D. Adhyavasāya-determinate ascertainment and judgement

Answer: D. Adhyavasāya-determinate ascertainment and judgement

Explanation: Buddhi determines; manas coordinates; ahaṁkāra appropriates. Buddhi remains material.

14. Mahat and buddhi are best understood as:

- A. One tattva viewed cosmically and psychologically B. Two halves of Puruṣa C. Two successive evolutes D. Two names of ahaṁkāra

Answer: A. One tattva viewed cosmically and psychologically

Explanation: Mahat is the cosmic and buddhi the psychological designation of the same first evolute.

15. Ahaṁkāra is principally:

- A. The I-maker appropriating functions as "I" and "mine" B. Reliable testimony C. Pure consciousness D. The final gross element

Answer: A. The I-maker appropriating functions as "I" and "mine"

Explanation: Ahaṁkāra individuates and appropriates reflected cognition and action; it is not Puruṣa.

16. Which is the exact tāmasa sequence?

A. Ahaṁkāra -> faculties -> tanmātras B. Ahaṁkāra -> five tanmātras -> five mahābhūtas C. Ahaṁkāra -> manas -> gross elements D. Ahaṁkāra -> buddhi -> Puruṣa

Answer: B. Ahaṁkāra -> five tanmātras -> five mahābhūtas

Explanation: The tāmasa aspect yields subtle elements and then gross elements; faculties arise from the sāttvika aspect.

17. How many Prakṛti-side tattvas are counted before adding Puruṣa?

A. Twenty-six B. Twenty-three C. Twenty-five D. Twenty-four

Answer: D. Twenty-four

Explanation: Prakṛti plus twenty-three evolutes make twenty-four; Puruṣa is twenty-fifth and not an evolute.

18. Saṅghāta-parārthatvāt argues that:

A. Psychophysical aggregates function for a conscious beneficiary distinct from them B. Every aggregate is conscious C. Liberation proves Prakṛti is many D. Only scripture establishes Puruṣa

Answer: A. Psychophysical aggregates function for a conscious beneficiary distinct from them

Explanation: Body, senses and mind are instrumental complexes; Sāṁkhya infers a conscious beneficiary.

19. Which proof infers Puruṣa because pleasure, pain and delusion require an experiencer?

A. Bhoktṛ-bhāvāt B. Samanvayāt C. Adhiṣṭhānāt D. Triguṇādi-viparyayāt

Answer: A. Bhoktṛ-bhāvāt

Explanation: Bhoktṛ-bhāvāt argues from experienced states to a subject distinct from those objectifiable states.

20. What is the strongest measured verdict on the five proofs for Puruṣa?

A. They prove an active creator B. Cumulatively they support a subject-pole more strongly than many eternal inactive Puruṣas C. They prove only Prakṛti D. Each proves many Puruṣas deductively

Answer: B. Cumulatively they support a subject-pole more strongly than many eternal inactive Puruṣas

Explanation: The arguments have phenomenological force, but further premises are needed for eternity, inactivity and plurality.

21. Why does Sāṁkhya posit many Puruṣas?

A. Distinct births, capacities, experiences and non-simultaneous liberation B. The Veda denies a witness C. Prakṛti is plural D. Each body manufactures consciousness

Answer: A. Distinct births, capacities, experiences and non-simultaneous liberation

Explanation: Plurality safeguards non-transferable experience, karma and liberation, though individuation remains disputed.

22. Advaita's central objection to Puruṣa plurality is that:

A. Puruṣa is material B. Differences belong to upādhis; pure consciousness lacks an individuating feature C. Plurality abolishes karma D. All selves must create

Answer: B. Differences belong to upādhis; pure consciousness lacks an individuating feature

Explanation: Advaita claims Sāṁkhya proves many mental streams, not many pure consciousnesses.

23. Jīva in Sāṁkhya is:

A. The single cosmic Prakṛti B. Puruṣa empirically conditioned through buddhi, ahaṁkāra and subtle body C. The gross body alone D. A twenty-sixth tattva

Answer: B. Puruṣa empirically conditioned through buddhi, ahaṁkāra and subtle body

Explanation: Jīva is the embodied empirical subject generated by association and identification, not another principle.

24. Which statement avoids turning Puruṣa into an agent?

A. Agency belongs to Prakṛti's evolutes while Puruṣa witnesses B. Puruṣa intentionally starts evolution C. Puruṣa judges mentally D. Puruṣa transforms into buddhi

Answer: A. Agency belongs to Prakṛti's evolutes while Puruṣa witnesses

Explanation: All activity belongs to the guṇic apparatus; productive agency attributed to Puruṣa is bondage-producing error.

25. Satkāryavāda maintains that:

A. All change is illusory B. The effect is wholly new C. Only efficient causes matter D. The effect pre-exists latently in its material cause and becomes manifest

Answer: D. The effect pre-exists latently in its material cause and becomes manifest

Explanation: Pre-existence is latent and determinate, not visible or spatial presence of the gross effect.

26. Asadakaraṇāt means:

A. Effect wholly differs from cause B. Only atoms are eternal C. What is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced D. Every cause is conscious

Answer: C. What is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced

Explanation: Production cannot turn sheer non-being into being; it manifests a determinate grounded effect.

27. Upādāna-grahaṇāt emphasises:

A. Unreality of matter B. Identity of Puruṣa and Prakṛti C. Need for a creator D. Selection of a specific material cause for a specific effect

Answer: D. Selection of a specific material cause for a specific effect

Explanation: One selects milk for curd and mango seed for mango tree; specificity supports latent determination.

28. Sarvasambhavābhāvāt denies that:

A. Effects have names B. Causes possess powers C. Transformation is real D. Everything can arise from everything

Answer: D. Everything can arise from everything

Explanation: Sheer prior non-being cannot explain why only certain causes yield certain effects.

29. Śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt argues from:

A. Puruṣa's will B. Destruction of prior absence C. A cause producing only what lies within its determinate capacity D. Scriptural command

Answer: C. A cause producing only what lies within its determinate capacity

Explanation: A specific potency is directed toward a specific producible effect; Sāṃkhya reads this as latent grounding.

30. Kāraṇa-bhāvāt claims that:

A. Only form persists B. Causation requires God C. Cause and effect are unrelated D. The effect retains the material nature of its cause

Answer: D. The effect retains the material nature of its cause

Explanation: Gold remains through ornaments and threads through cloth; new arrangement is not new substance from nothing.

31. Sāṃkhya pariṇāmavāda differs from Advaita vivartavāda because:

A. Sāṃkhya affirms real material transformation; Advaita, apparent transformation B. Sāṃkhya makes Brahman the material cause C. Both deny any world D. Advaita accepts many Prakṛtis

Answer: A. Sāṃkhya affirms real material transformation; Advaita, apparent transformation

Explanation: Both deny creation from nothing, but differ decisively over real evolution versus appearance.

32. Nyāya asatkāryavāda holds that before production the effect:

A. Exists grossly inside cause B. Is Brahman C. Is absent as effect (prāgabhāva) and begins as a new product D. Is concealed

Answer: C. Is absent as effect (prāgabhāva) and begins as a new product

Explanation: Nyāya explains specificity through causal powers and conditions, not latent effect-pre-existence.

33. In the mango-seed example, the safest Sāṃkhya formulation is:

A. Soil alone is the material cause B. The seed contains mango-specific latent potency that really transforms under suitable conditions C. A miniature gross tree is spatially hidden in the seed D. Puruṣa actively designs the tree

Answer: B. The seed contains mango-specific latent potency that really transforms under suitable conditions

Explanation: The seed is the determinate material continuum; soil, water and heat are auxiliaries. Satkāryavāda is not miniature-object identity.

34. Which criticism says satkāryavāda merely redescribes causal capacity as pre-existence?

A. The Nyāya objection B. The Yoga objection C. Buddhist two-truths theory D. Mīmāṃsā testimony theory

Answer: A. The Nyāya objection

Explanation: Nyāya grants determinate powers while denying that the effect exists before production.

35. Bondage in Sāṃkhya is fundamentally:

A. Prakṛti's existence itself B. Divine punishment C. Aviveka and abhimāna-non-discrimination and false appropriation D. A real mutation of Puruṣa

Answer: C. Aviveka and abhimāna-non-discrimination and false appropriation

Explanation: Buddhi acts and reflects consciousness; ahaṃkāra appropriates. Puruṣa remains unchanged.

36. Kaivalya is attained through:

A. Ritual creation of a new self B. Union of Puruṣa and Prakṛti C. Destruction of all Puruṣas D. Stable viveka-jñāna distinguishing Puruṣa from every guṇic process

Answer: D. Stable viveka-jñāna distinguishing Puruṣa from every guṇic process

Explanation: Kaivalya is isolation, not union with Brahman or God and not annihilation of Prakṛti.

37. Which formulation distinguishes jīvanmukti and videhamukti in Sāṃkhya?

A. Jīvanmukti means becoming God B. Videhamukti destroys Prakṛti universally C. Sāṃkhya rejects bodily continuation after knowledge D. Discrimination may arise while bodily momentum continues; disembodiment follows when it ends

Answer: D. Discrimination may arise while bodily momentum continues; disembodiment follows when it ends

Explanation: The potter's-wheel analogy explains residual embodiment; the liberated witness does not become an agent.

38. Classical Sāṃkhya is called nirīśvara because:

A. It identifies Puruṣa with Īśvara B. It rejects inference C. Its world-process and liberation do not require a creator God D. It denies consciousness

Answer: C. Its world-process and liberation do not require a creator God

Explanation: Prakṛti, plural Puruṣas and discrimination are sufficient, distinguishing Sāṃkhya from theistic Yoga.

39. What is the contact problem?

A. How gross elements touch B. How testimony reaches Veda C. How universals are perceived D. How inactive Puruṣa and unconscious Prakṛti can coordinate at all

Answer: C. How universals are perceived

Explanation: Evolution, experience and bondage require coordination, yet neither principle can initiate intentional relation.

40. What does the lame-blind analogy intend to show?

A. Identity of Puruṣa and Prakṛti B. Puruṣa as efficient cause C. Complementarity: consciousness without action and action without consciousness D. Prakṛti sees its goal

Answer: D. Prakṛti sees its goal

Explanation: It illustrates supplementation, but actual lame-blind cooperation presupposes communication and intention.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

Questions 41-48 target recurring conceptual and directive errors while continuing C -> A -> B -> D.

41. Why does Śaṃkhya reject the magnet-iron analogy as a complete solution?

A. A magnet exerts causal force, whereas Puruṣa is wholly inactive B. It denies continuity C. Iron is conscious D. It proves too many Puruṣas

Answer: D. It proves too many Puruṣas

Explanation: The analogy imports efficacy that strict Puruṣa-inactivity excludes.

42. If proximity is a real relation, Śaṃkhya argues that:

A. Only Prakṛti changes B. Liberation follows automatically C. Relation equals testimony D. Relational modification threatens independence; if unreal, it explains nothing

Answer: B. Liberation follows automatically

Explanation: The dilemma targets the explanatory status of sānnidhya.

43. Why is Sāṃkhya a pradhāna-malla for Śaṃkhya?

A. It is the strongest systematic rival centred on pradhāna, causation, self and liberation B. It alone accepts Upaniṣads C. It is identical with Advaita D. It denies material cause

Answer: C. It is identical with Advaita

Explanation: "Chief opponent" marks philosophical strength and proximity, not a casual insult.

44. Śaṃkhya's scriptural-causal objection is that the world-ground must be:

A. A gross element B. Conscious and knowing, not unconscious pradhāna C. Ahaṃkāra D. Many atomic selves

Answer: C. Ahaṃkāra

Explanation: He reads Upaniṣadic causation passages as attributing knowledge and purposiveness to the source.

45. What is Sāṃkhya's best reply to unconscious-teleology criticism?

A. Prakṛti is conscious B. Ordered functioning can arise from inherent guṇa-nature in Puruṣa's presence without planning C. World is illusion D. Puruṣa secretly acts

Answer: B. Ordered functioning can arise from inherent guṇa-nature in Puruṣa's presence without planning

Explanation: Milk-calf and natural-process analogies defend purposive functioning without a deliberating planner, though contested.

46. Which comparison is accurate?

A. Sāṃkhya accepts pariṇāma; Advaita protects Brahman through vivarta B. Both accept real transformation of the ultimate C. Advaita accepts many Prakṛtis D. Sāṃkhya makes māyā sole cause

Answer: A. Sāṃkhya accepts pariṇāma; Advaita protects Brahman through vivarta

Explanation: Sāṃkhya prioritises real material continuity; Advaita preserves ultimate changelessness through appearance.

47. A question saying "critically examine" requires:

A. A list without argument B. Definition alone C. Only objections D. Doctrine -> named objection -> Sāṃkhya reply -> residual judgement

Answer: D. Doctrine -> named objection -> Sāṃkhya reply -> residual judgement

Explanation: Directive fidelity demands exposition and assessment, not one-sided criticism.

48. Which statement is an exam trap rather than sound doctrine?

A. Puruṣa is inactive witness B. Rajas energises both branches C. Government officially adopted a 2026 national Sāṃkhya mental-health paradigm D. Mahat and buddhi are one tattva under two aspects

Answer: C. Government officially adopted a 2026 national Sāṃkhya mental-health paradigm

Explanation: No authoritative source supports that policy claim; classical doctrine must not be modernised through fabrication.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 10 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Independent learner-practice models, not official UPSC answer keys. Wording, year, question number and marks follow the verified local PYQ corpus.

2018 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Question: Is Puruṣa one or many? Explain the Sāṃkhya position in this regard and give arguments in support of your answer.

Demand decoding

Fix Puruṣa's numerical status, derive plurality from empirical and soteriological differences, and test whether those differences really individuate pure consciousness.

Independent model answer

Samkhya accepts **many Purusas**. Each Purusa is eternal, inactive, attributeless pure consciousness, but numerical plurality is required to explain differences among embodied streams.

The standard arguments are:

1. **Separate births and deaths:** one organism begins or ends without all doing so.
2. **Non-simultaneous activity:** when one sleeps, another acts.
3. **Diversity of experience:** pleasure, pain and knowledge differ among persons.
4. **Moral individuality:** karmic fruits attach to distinct empirical streams.
5. **Non-simultaneous liberation:** one person's release does not liberate all.

Advaita objects that attributeless consciousness cannot be numerically differentiated; apparent plurality may arise from distinct adjuncts. Samkhya replies that if only one Purusa existed, bondage and liberation would become universally simultaneous.

Verdict: Plurality protects moral and soteriological individuality, though the principle distinguishing qualitatively identical Purusas remains under-explained.

Why this earns marks

- States many numerically distinct but qualitatively alike Puruṣas.
- Uses birth/death, activity, experience, karma and liberation as arguments.
- Adds the Advaita upādhi objection and simultaneity reply.
- Ends with a qualified judgement on individuation.

2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: How do the Advaita Vedāntins react to the Prakṛtipariṇāma-vāda of the Sāṃkhya philosophy? How do the Sāṃkhyas defend their own position in this regard? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Present Advaita's objections to real transformation by unconscious Prakṛti, reconstruct Sāṃkhya's defence, and reach the balanced verdict required by "discuss".

Independent model answer

Samkhya holds that Prakriti really transforms into the world. The effect pre-exists in the cause and becomes manifest through **parinama**. Advaita accepts satkaryavada at a broad level but rejects independent unconscious Prakriti and real transformation of ultimate reality.

Sankara's objections are:

1. An unconscious pradhana cannot initiate purposive, ordered evolution.
2. If Purusa is inactive and Prakriti independent, their relation is unintelligible.
3. The Upanisads present an intelligent principle, not unconscious matter, as world-ground.
4. Real transformation would compromise the changelessness of ultimate reality.
5. Two independent absolutes leave their coordination unexplained.

Advaita therefore proposes **vivartavada**: the world is an appearance of Brahman through maya, not a real transformation of Brahman.

Samkhya replies that effects share the guna-structure of their cause and require material continuity. Milk changes into curd without an external intelligent planner; similarly Prakriti's inherent tendency and Purusa's proximity suffice. A God does not explain how consciousness creates unconscious matter, whereas Prakriti naturally contains the material potency of the world.

Verdict: Samkhya explains real causal continuity better; Advaita presses the deeper problem of how unconscious teleology and dual coordination are possible.

Why this earns marks

- Defines satkāryavāda and pariṇāma before comparison.
- Organises objections around causation, teleology, scripture and relation.
- Gives replies from material continuity and inherent guṇa-potency.
- Distinguishes pariṇāma from vivarta and balances both sides.

2019 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question: Critically discuss the metaphysical status of a Jīva and a Puruṣa according to Sāṃkhya philosophy.

Demand decoding

Distinguish the unconditioned witness from the empirical self, explain reflection and appropriation, and address the paradox of bondage without change in Puruṣa.

Independent model answer

Puruṣa is pure, eternal, inactive consciousness-witness, not agent or product. **Jīva** is Puruṣa apparently associated with the subtle body, buddhi, ahamkara, manas, senses and karmic dispositions.

Puruṣa	Jīva
pure consciousness	empirical embodied subject
inactive witness	appears as knower, doer, enjoyer
unbound in itself	subject to bondage and transmigration
plural and eternal	psychophysical stream around one Puruṣa

Buddhi is material but sattva-predominant and reflects consciousness. Ahamkara appropriates this reflected awareness as "I know" and "I act." Bondage belongs strictly to Prakriti's apparatus, yet is attributed to Puruṣa through non-discrimination.

The criticism is severe: if Puruṣa is never really bound, liberation appears unnecessary; if Jīva alone is bound, it is unclear who seeks release. Samkhya replies that liberation removes false identification, not a real modification of Puruṣa.

Why this earns marks

- Separates Puruṣa from jīva and denies that jīva is another tattva.
- Explains buddhi-reflection and ahaṁkāra's appropriation.
- Handles bondage without making Puruṣa an agent.
- Raises and answers the liberation paradox.

2019 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Which Sāṃkhya proof for the existence of Prakṛti actually shows that there can be only one Prakṛti? Justify your answer.

Demand decoding

Identify the proof supporting numerical unity, distinguish it from the other existence-proofs, justify its inference, and state its limitation.

Independent model answer

The decisive proof is **avibhagat vaisvarūpyasya**: the differentiated universe points to an undivided source. The cosmos displays immense plurality but also systemic unity and reciprocal transformation. Its differentiated forms must emerge from one unmanifest matrix in which they are not yet divided.

The other proofs establish the need for a material ground:

- *bhedanam parimanat*: finite effects require a ground.
- *samanvayat*: common guna-structure suggests a common cause.
- *karyatah pravṛtteh*: productive activity presupposes potency.
- *karana-karya-vibhagat*: manifest effect differs from unmanifest causal state.

These support Prakṛti's existence, but they do not as directly exclude multiple root causes. The fifth proof specifically moves from unified diversification to one undivided source.

An opponent may argue that cosmic coordination does not logically prove numerical unity; several coordinated causes are possible. Sāṃkhya replies that multiple Prakṛtis with the same guna-constitution are explanatorily redundant and would require a higher principle coordinating them.

Verdict: The proof is abductive rather than demonstrative: one Prakṛti is the most economical common material explanation of an interconnected guna-world.

Why this earns marks

- Names avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya precisely.
- Shows why the other proofs do not establish unity as directly.
- Bridges coordinated diversity to an undivided source.
- Qualifies the inference as abductive, not demonstrative.

2020 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question: "A mango tree is grown out of a mango seed." How will Sāṃkhya system explain this process through their theory of causation by rejecting their rival perspectives?

Demand decoding

Apply all five satkāryavāda arguments to seed-tree causation, explain pariṇāma, reject rivals, and avoid the miniature-tree fallacy.

Independent model answer

Sāṃkhya explains the mango tree through **satkāryavāda**: the effect exists latently in its material cause before manifestation. The seed is not an actual miniature tree, but it contains the determinate material potency that can unfold into that tree under suitable conditions.

Five arguments support the doctrine:

1. **Asadakaranat**: what is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced.
2. **Upadana-grahanat**: production requires a specific material cause.

3. **Sarvasambhavabhavat**: everything cannot arise from everything.
4. **Saktasya sakya-karanat**: a cause produces only what lies within its capacity.
5. **Karana-bhavat**: effect retains the nature of the cause.

The seed-to-tree process is **parinamavada**, real transformation. Production is manifestation; destruction is return to an unmanifest condition. Soil, water and heat are auxiliaries, while the seed carries mango-specific causal power.

Nyaya's *asatkaryavada* says the tree is newly produced and had prior absence. Samkhya objects that if wholly absent, its production from this rather than any cause is unintelligible. Nyaya replies that capacity, not latent effect, limits production.

Buddhist dependent origination treats seed and tree as momentary causal series without enduring material identity. Samkhya argues that a shared substrate and continuity better explain determinate transformation.

Advaita *vivartavada* treats worldly transformation as appearance relative to Brahman. Samkhya insists the empirical world and its changes are real and require real material evolution.

Verdict: *Satkaryavada* powerfully explains specificity and continuity, though critics may say it redescribes capacity as pre-existence and weakens genuine novelty.

Why this earns marks

- Applies all five causal arguments to mango-specific production.
- Separates the material seed from auxiliary conditions.
- Rejects the gross miniature-tree reading.
- Engages Nyāya, Buddhist and Advaita alternatives.

2021 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the Sāṃkhya view on three guṇas (guṇa-traya) and their modifications.

Demand decoding

Define the three constitutive guṇas, explain equilibrium and both modifications, and connect their interplay to cosmology and psychology.

Independent model answer

Prakriti consists of **sattva, rajas and tamas**, not as qualities added to a substance but as its constitutive strands.

Guna	Character	Psychological expression	Physical tendency
Sattva	illumination, lightness	clarity, pleasure, knowledge	upward/light
Rajas	activity, stimulation	desire, effort, restlessness	motion
Tamas	restraint, heaviness	ignorance, dullness, obstruction	inertia/downward

They are mutually opposed yet cooperative, like oil, wick and flame. Every product contains all three in different proportions.

In primordial Prakriti they undergo **sarupa-parinama**, homogeneous internal change that preserves equilibrium. Purusa's proximity disturbs balance and produces **virupa-parinama**, heterogeneous predominance initiating evolution. Rajas activates; sattva and tamas differentiate into cognitive and material lines.

Modification never creates substance from nothing. Each tattva is a new configuration of the same guna-material. This grounds both cosmology and psychology: knowledge, desire, inertia, senses and elements are stages of one material evolution.

Verdict: Guna theory unifies mind and matter without reducing one to the other, but it risks explaining diverse phenomena through highly elastic principles.

Why this earns marks

- Treats guṇas as constituents, not detachable qualities.
- Explains cooperation, equilibrium and disequilibrium.
- Distinguishes *sarūpa* from *virūpa pariṇāma*.

- Connects modification to psychology and evolution.

2022 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: Examine and evaluate the proofs given by Sāṃkhya philosophy to prove the existence of Puruṣa.

Demand decoding

Explain all five proofs and evaluate whether they establish a subject-pole, an eternal Puruṣa and plurality with equal success.

Independent model answer

Samkhya gives five cumulative proofs:

1. **Sanghata-pararthatvat:** aggregates exist for another; body-mind serves a conscious subject.
2. **Trigunadi-viparyayat:** the witness must be opposite to the changing, unconscious gunas.
3. **Adhistanat:** organized experience requires a presiding consciousness.
4. **Bhoktr-bhavat:** pleasure and pain require an experiencer.
5. **Kaivalyartham pravrtteh:** striving for liberation presupposes a liberable witness.

The arguments jointly distinguish the objectifiable psychophysical apparatus from a non-objective subject. They are strongest phenomenologically: experience seems to require a standpoint not reducible to what is experienced.

Buddhists deny that aggregates exist "for" a separate owner and explain experience as a causal stream. Advaita accepts witness-consciousness but denies its plurality.

Verdict: The proofs establish a subject-pole more plausibly than they establish many eternal, wholly inactive Purusas. Their cumulative force exceeds each argument taken alone.

Why this earns marks

- Presents all five technical proofs accurately.
- Explains their cumulative phenomenological logic.
- Separates witness-proof from proof of plural eternal witnesses.
- Uses Buddhist and Advaita objections evaluatively.

2023 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: "If Puruṣa and Prakṛti are two completely independent realities, then no relation between the two is possible." In the light of this statement make a brief presentation of Śaṅkara's criticism of Sāṃkhya dualism.

Demand decoding

Reconstruct Śaṅkara's relation-dilemma, test Sāṃkhya's proximity analogies, and judge whether dualist coordination is intelligible.

Independent model answer

Sankara argues that Samkhya's two independent principles cannot initiate a coordinated world-process. Purusa is inactive and changeless; Prakriti is unconscious. Neither can intentionally approach, affect or know the other.

If proximity is a real relation, both principles undergo relational modification and lose absolute independence. If proximity is unreal, it cannot explain the disturbance of guna-equilibrium. If it is beginningless, evolution should be continuous and liberation impossible.

The lame-and-blind analogy assumes cooperation but does not explain its ground: the lame person consciously directs the blind, whereas Purusa cannot act and Prakriti cannot understand.

Samkhya replies that proximity is not physical contact but reflective presence. A magnet moves iron without changing itself, and Prakriti operates for Purusa like milk flowing for the calf.

Verdict: The analogies clarify non-mechanical influence but do not fully explain how two independent absolutes enter a purposive relation.

Why this earns marks

- Answers the quoted impossibility claim directly.

- Develops the real/unreal/beginningless relation dilemma.
- Tests lame-blind, magnet-iron and milk-calf analogies.
- Concludes on coordination without agency.

2024 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question: Present an account of evolution of Prakṛti as propounded in Sāṃkhyakārikā. In this context, also explain the difference between buddhi, mahat and ahaṃkāra.

Demand decoding

Give the exact evolutionary sequence and count, then distinguish mahat/buddhi from ahaṃkāra without making mahat and buddhi separate tattvas.

Independent model answer

Evolution begins when the equilibrium of sattva, rajas and tamas in avyakta Prakṛti is disturbed in the presence of Puruṣa.

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Prakṛiti
↓
Mahat / Buddhi
↓
Ahaṃkāra
+- sattvika line -> manas + 5 cognitive senses + 5 action senses
+- tamasa line   -> 5 tanmatras -> 5 gross elements
+- rajas         -> energizes both lines

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Together with Prakṛiti and Puruṣa, the evolutes form twenty-five tattvas.

Mahat is the first cosmic evolute-the "great" principle of determination in the universal process. **Buddhi** is the same tattva viewed psychologically as individual determinative intellect; it performs adhyavasaya, judgement and discrimination. Thus mahat and buddhi are not two separate tattvas.

Ahaṃkāra is the next evolute, the I-maker that appropriates experience as "I" and "mine." From its sattvika aspect arise the eleven faculties; from its tamasa aspect arise five subtle elements. Rajas supplies activity.

Buddhi is material, not consciousness. Its sattva-like transparency reflects Puruṣa, creating the appearance of a conscious intellect. Ahaṃkāra misappropriates reflected consciousness and generates bondage.

Critics question how mere proximity initiates evolution and how unconscious Prakṛiti acts purposively. Sāṃkhya replies that transformation is inherent in the gunas and serves the dual ends of experience and liberation.

Verdict: The scheme unifies cosmology and psychology with remarkable economy, though its first transition from independent Puruṣa to disturbed Prakṛiti remains the weakest link.

Why this earns marks

- Gives the exact sequence and both evolutionary branches.
- Counts twenty-five tattvas without making Puruṣa an evolute.
- Distinguishes determination from I-appropriation.
- Adds contact and teleology evaluation.

2025 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question: Why does Śaṅkara consider Sāṃkhya Philosophy as his chief opponent (pradhāna malla)? Examine his arguments against Sāṃkhya Philosophy.

Demand decoding

Explain why Sāṃkhya is Advaita's strongest rival, then examine Śaṅkara's scriptural, causal, teleological, relational and soteriological objections.

Independent model answer

Sāṃkhya is Advaita's chief opponent because it offers the strongest systematic rival account of one world-ground, causation, bondage and liberation. Both seek an ultimate explanation beneath plurality and accept that ignorance causes bondage, but Sāṃkhya proposes unconscious Pradhana and many Puruṣas where Advaita proposes non-dual Brahman.

Sankara's principal criticisms are:

1. **Scriptural:** Upanisadic causation passages describe an intelligent knowing source, not unconscious Pradhana.
2. **Teleological:** unconscious Prakriti cannot produce an ordered world for experience and liberation.
3. **Contact problem:** inactive Purusa and independent Prakriti cannot enter an intelligible relation.
4. **Analogy failure:** milk-calf and lame-blind examples presuppose structures absent from the two principles.
5. **Plurality problem:** qualitatively identical, attributeless Purusas lack a differentiating principle.
6. **Causal criticism:** real transformation of the ultimate threatens its independence; Advaita prefers apparent transformation.
7. **Bondage paradox:** an eternally inactive witness cannot really be bound or liberated.

Samkhya replies that material continuity requires Prakriti; the gunas explain mind and matter; plurality protects individual karma; and intelligence need not plan natural transformation. Advaita, in turn, must explain how maya and appearance arise without compromising Brahman.

Sankara treats Samkhya seriously because it cannot be dismissed as crude materialism. It shares renunciatory and discriminative aims, supplies a mature causal theory, and deeply influenced the conceptual vocabulary of Indian thought.

Verdict: Sankara's strongest objection is not mere scriptural disagreement but explanatory coordination: Samkhya cannot fully show how an unconscious independent cause evolves for an inactive independent consciousness. Yet Advaita replaces this with its own maya problem.

Why this earns marks

- Explains pradhāna-malla as strength and proximity.
- Covers scriptural, teleological, relational, plurality and bondage objections.
- Includes material-continuity and nirīśvara replies.
- Compares Sāṃkhya's gap with Advaita's māyā problem.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

These six questions are original practice, not PYQs. Models are independent learner answers.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Why is Sāṃkhya epistemology indispensable to its metaphysics?

Demand decoding

Link the three-pramāṇa scheme to imperceptible principles; explain sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa and evaluate its reach.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya metaphysics depends on epistemology because its two ultimate realities are not ordinary objects of perception. It admits only **pratyakṣa**, **anumāna** and **āptavacana/śabda**. Root Prakṛti is imperceptible through subtlety, while Puruṣa is the non-objective witness; neither can simply be introduced as a perceptual datum.

The decisive bridge is **sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa anumāna**. From finite, coordinated and guṇa-structured effects, Sāṃkhya infers one unmanifest material ground. From objectifiable aggregates, experienced pleasure and pain, and striving for release, it infers consciousness distinct from the guṇas. Testimony can confirm these conclusions, but inference permits argument without presupposing scripture.

This economy gives methodological unity: unseen entities answer defined explanatory needs. Yet it is underdetermined. Cārvāka doubts inference to a never-perceived term; Nyāya accepts inference but proposes atoms, selves and Īśvara. Thus Sāṃkhya metaphysics is an inferential construction whose force depends on whether general correlation warrants these particular unseen principles.

Why this earns marks

- Opens with a thesis tailored to the directive and marks.
- Uses named Sāṃkhya concepts and an exact doctrinal distinction.

- Builds claim, evidence/example and analysis rather than listing labels.
- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish material cause, auxiliary conditions and conscious witness in Sāṃkhya causation.

Demand decoding

Identify material continuity, enabling conditions and Puruṣa as a non-agentive witness through the mango-seed example.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya explains production through an **upādāna-kāraṇa**, a material cause that really transforms. In the mango case, the seed bears determinate mango-producing potency; soil, water, heat and cultivation are enabling conditions. The gross tree is not spatially hidden in the seed, but its determinate effect-form is latent in that material continuum.

Puruṣa is neither material cause nor productive agent. It is pure inactive consciousness. Its presence makes the process experienced, while every transformation belongs to Prakṛti and the guṇas. This preserves satkāryavāda: an effect arises from an appropriate material basis, not sheer non-being. It also preserves pariṇāmavāda: the substrate undergoes real reconfiguration.

Calling Puruṣa the designer would import Nyāya or theistic Yoga; calling auxiliaries the sole material cause would destroy causal continuity. Sāṃkhya gains a precise naturalistic account of transformation, though Puruṣa's non-causal presence reopens the contact problem.

Why this earns marks

- Opens with a thesis tailored to the directive and marks.
- Uses named Sāṃkhya concepts and an exact doctrinal distinction.
- Builds claim, evidence/example and analysis rather than listing labels.
- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Does guṇa theory successfully unify Sāṃkhya cosmology and psychology? Evaluate.

Demand decoding

Explain the three guṇas, both modifications and their work in evolution and cognition; weigh integration against elasticity.

Model answer

The guṇas are constitutive strands of Prakṛti. **Sattva** illuminates and is associated with clarity and pleasure; **rajas** activates and is associated with effort and pain; **tamas** restrains and obscures, producing heaviness and delusion. Their equilibrium is avyakta Prakṛti. **Sarūpa-pariṇāma** is homogeneous change compatible with equilibrium; **virūpa-pariṇāma** begins with unequal predominance and generates differentiated tattvas.

Cosmologically, guṇa transformation explains the sequence from mahat/buddhi and ahaṃkāra to faculties, tanmātras and gross elements. Rajas energises both the sāttvika cognitive line and tāmasa material line. Psychologically, sattva makes buddhi transparent to reflected consciousness, rajas drives action, and tamas obstructs discrimination. Mind and matter are continuous products of one material principle.

This is a major achievement: one triadic grammar connects physical density, affect, cognition and temperament. Yet its breadth is also a weakness. Almost any event can be redescribed as a guṇa-mixture, with limited independent criteria for measuring proportions. Further, it explains structured change after disequilibrium better than why inactive Puruṣa's proximity occasions it.

Guṇa theory therefore integrates Sāṃkhya's architecture more strongly than it independently proves its ontology.

Why this earns marks

- Opens with a thesis tailored to the directive and marks.
- Uses named Sāṃkhya concepts and an exact doctrinal distinction.
- Builds claim, evidence/example and analysis rather than listing labels.
- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Is Sāṃkhya's doctrine of many Puruṣas philosophically necessary? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Present plurality arguments, distinguish empirical streams from witnesses, include Advaita's individuation objection, and give a qualified verdict.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya requires many Puruṣas to preserve the non-transferability of embodied life. Birth and death occur separately; sense-capacities differ; one person acts while another sleeps; pleasure, pain and karmic consequences are not universally shared; and one person's discrimination does not liberate everyone. A single Puruṣa would make bondage and release simultaneous and universal.

Plurality protects moral and soteriological individuality while keeping consciousness free from guṇic difference. Puruṣas are numerically many but qualitatively alike: each pure, changeless and inactive. Distinct subtle bodies carry dispositions and provide different loci in which consciousness is reflected.

Advaita objects that all cited differences belong to bodies and minds, not attributeless consciousness. Sāṃkhya may prove many cittas or jīvas without proving many Puruṣas. Nyāya, though pluralist, adds that an inactive witness poorly bears moral responsibility. Sāṃkhya replies that making Puruṣa an agent would turn bondage into a real modification; empirical agency must remain in buddhi and ahaṃkāra.

Plurality is systemically necessary for Sāṃkhya's realism and individual liberation. Philosophically, however, its evidence establishes distinct psychophysical streams more clearly than an ultimate individuator among qualitatively identical witnesses.

Why this earns marks

- Opens with a thesis tailored to the directive and marks.
- Uses named Sāṃkhya concepts and an exact doctrinal distinction.
- Builds claim, evidence/example and analysis rather than listing labels.
- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Sāṃkhya secures causal continuity at the cost of genuine novelty." Critically examine satkāryavāda and pariṇāmavāda.

Demand decoding

Derive the five arguments, explain real transformation, answer novelty and rivals, and judge whether latent effect exceeds causal capacity.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya's **satkāryavāda** holds that an effect pre-exists latently in its material cause; production is manifestation, not creation from sheer non-being. Its form is **pariṇāmavāda**, because the material cause really transforms. The doctrine explains why production is continuous, determinate and intelligible.

Five arguments support it. **Asadakaraṇāt**: what is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced. **Upādāna-grahaṇāt**: a specific effect requires a specific material cause. **Sarvasambhavābhāvāt**: everything does not arise from everything. **Śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt**: a cause produces only what lies within its capacity. **Kāraṇa-bhāvāt**: the effect retains the material being of its cause, as cloth retains threads or an ornament gold. A mango tree therefore emerges from mango-specific potency in the seed under auxiliary conditions; no gross miniature tree is hidden there.

The novelty charge is partly justified. If effect and cause were simply identical, causal effort would be redundant. Sāṃkhya answers through **avasthā-bheda**: latent and manifest states differ, while new organisation and properties are real modifications of an enduring continuum. Novelty is configurational, not creation ex nihilo.

Nyāya gives the effect prior absence and treats it as a new whole. It explains specificity through causal power without identifying power with latent effect. Sāṃkhya replies that a power determinately for X already grounds X in the cause; otherwise restriction is named, not explained. Advaita denies creation from non-being but replaces real transformation of the ultimate with vivarta. Sāṃkhya objects that appearance explains empirical material continuity less directly.

Satkāryavāda secures continuity and specificity by restricting novelty to manifestation and transformation. Its unresolved issue is whether latent effect explains causal capacity or merely redescribes it; nevertheless it remains a coherent alternative to both new production and merely apparent change.

Why this earns marks

- Opens with a thesis tailored to the directive and marks.
- Uses named Sāṃkhya concepts and an exact doctrinal distinction.
- Builds claim, evidence/example and analysis rather than listing labels.
- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: “The purity of Puruṣa and the activity of Prakṛti make liberation intelligible but their conjunction unintelligible.” Examine.

Demand decoding

Integrate reflection, jīva, bondage, viveka, kaivalya, analogies, Śaṃkara's dilemma and Sāṃkhya replies; evaluate the trade-off.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya assigns consciousness and activity to different principles. Puruṣa is pure, changeless and inactive witness; Prakṛti is unconscious but productive. This makes liberation intelligible: if consciousness itself changed and suffered, release could not be stable. Bondage can instead be **aviveka**, false identification with material processes, and liberation **viveka-jñāna**, recognition that every change belongs to Prakṛti.

Empirical life is explained through reflection. Sattva-predominant buddhi, though insentient, reflects Puruṣa's consciousness; ahaṃkāra appropriates cognition and action as “I know” and “I do.” Jīva is Puruṣa appearing through this subtle-body complex, not another tattva. When discrimination becomes firm, Prakṛti's binding display ceases for that Puruṣa. Bodily momentum may continue like a potter's wheel (jīvanmukti) until videhamukti. Kaivalya is isolation, not union with God; classical Sāṃkhya is nirīśvara.

The separation creates the contact problem. If the principles are independent, what disturbs guṇa-equilibrium, produces reflection or directs evolution toward experience and release? Sāṃkhya invokes **sānnidhya**, mere proximity. Lame-blind depicts complementary capacities; magnet-iron depicts activation without deliberation; crystal-flower depicts apparent colouring; dancer-spectator depicts withdrawal after disclosure.

Śaṃkara argues that these images borrow what the theory denies. The lame directs the blind intentionally; a magnet exerts force; crystal-flower explains appearance but not cosmic initiation. If proximity is real, independence and changelessness are qualified; if unreal, it explains nothing; if invariant and beginningless, manifestation should not cease. Unconscious pradhāna also seems unable to organise a world “for” another.

Sāṃkhya replies that natural purposiveness need not be conscious planning: milk nourishes a calf without deliberation, and guṇas have inherent transformative tendencies. Adding Īśvara does not explain material continuity. It may also charge Advaita with replacing coordination by the difficult relation of Brahman, māyā and appearance.

The quotation is substantially correct. The purity/activity division gives a powerful non-reductive account of consciousness and liberation, but reflected experience and purposive coordination remain Sāṃkhya's deepest metaphysical gap.

Why this earns marks

- Opens with a thesis tailored to the directive and marks.
- Uses named Sāṃkhya concepts and an exact doctrinal distinction.
- Builds claim, evidence/example and analysis rather than listing labels.
- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.